

CRASH OF THE CARNIVAL: HOW THE ISL DREAM FELL FROM PROMISE TO PERIL

Once Indian football's showpiece, the Indian Super League now finds its future on **tenterhooks.**



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The launch of the Indian Super League in 2014 was meant to elevate the profile of the sport in the country. And for a fleeting period, the hype was real. Leading — albeit ageing — football stars from the 1990s and 2000s, and a mix of Indian cinema and cricket, helped establish an entertaining product. The three-month-long competition, which wasn't recognised by the Asian Football Confederation (AFC) then, proved to be an instant hit.

But once the novelty factor wore off and the glitz was stripped away, the league struggled to reach the heights of its initial years. While the ISL brought about improved standards and professionalism, the popularity of the league has dwindled after 11 seasons.

Ballooning costs

The first season of the ISL, which had eight new teams, saw an average attendance of 25,408. But in the recently concluded season, despite boasting the iconic Kolkata outfits of Mohun Bagan and East Bengal, the numbers dropped to 11,084.

High operational costs, poor gate revenue, and diminishing broadcast numbers mean clubs have struggled to make it a profitable venture. In 2014, ISL's TV viewership amounted to 429 million, but the cumulative numbers for TV and digital platforms fell to around 130

million for 2024-25.

"Though clubs in the UK or Germany function this way, it becomes much more challenging for Indian clubs to follow that blueprint because of the cost that comes in, and the return on investment is almost negligible," a source told *Sportstar*. An estimated expenditure of a mid-table ISL club last season was close to ₹60 crore, with nearly half the amount written off as a loss in the balance sheet. An ISL team receives around ₹13-16 crore annually from the central revenue pool of the league. In comparison, an Indian Premier League (IPL) team receives a whopping ₹425 crore.

Of the eight original franchises, only five remain standing. FC Pune City shut operations due to financial woes, Delhi Dynamos moved base to Odisha to lower expenses, and three-time champion ATK made way for the entry of Mohun Bagan into the ISL, when the league was granted top-tier status.

"When Delhi Dynamos shifted to Odisha, the government offered the



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